his party, his government and its programmes were all following a mantra of 'Women First', he pointed to his cabinet: 'You will see that women have been given important portfolios.' He went on to point out two photographs from the China-hosted Shanghai Cooperation Organisation which had gone viral on social media at the time. 'In both photos,' Modi said, 'among all the men you can see only two women. Everybody else was a man. This photo was of defence and foreign ministers of many countries. Among them was a photo of Sushma Swaraj, who was the only [female] foreign minister, and the second was of Nirmala Sitharaman.'[64]

The Modi government also focused on the message of women entering hitherto male-dominated fields, especially in the military domain. From the Republic Day parade in 2020 being commanded for the first time by a woman officer to the Air Force commissioning its first women combat fighter pilots in 2019 and announcing in 2020 that women pilots were being trained to fly its new Rafales to announcing an all-women crew on board Air India—each of these has been promoted by the BJP as a political triumph.

For instance, Modi, speaking on his *Mann ki Baat* radio programme in October 2021, pointed out that the number of women in police and central armed forces had more than doubled in six years. He declared that the Army and the police were no longer all-male bastions and that this trend would lead to 'new age policing' with women in uniform becoming role models for 'lakhs of daughters'. He was referring to Bureau of Police Research and Development data which showed that the number of women in police forces had risen to 2.15 lakh in 2020, up from 1.05 lakh in 2014, the year he took over as prime minister.[65] Similarly, when his government decided to open up admissions in Sainik Schools—managed by Sainik School Societies and overseen by the Ministry of Defence to prepare students for entry into the defence services—Modi announced the decision from the ramparts of the Red Fort during his Independence Day speech. 'I used to receive messages from lakhs of daughters of our country that they, too, want to study in Sainik Schools,' he said. 'Two-and-a-half years ago, in the Sainik School in Mizoram, we started the experiment of admitting girl students. The government has now decided that all Sainik Schools in